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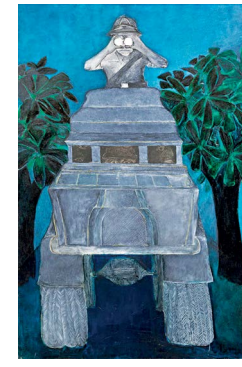
PAINTING OUTSIDE THE LINES

AN EXHIBITION OF KRISHEN KHANNA'S WORKS BRINGS TOGETHER A LIFETIME OF HIS OBSERVATIONS OF PEOPLE ON THE EDGES, ON THE MOVE, AND FOREVER EVOLVING

A Krishen Khanna exhibition in 2026 is not an ordinary event. It's a record of the zeitgeist of a century, seen through the eyes of a cultural giant who lived every version of a nation that birthed itself from the ashes of Partition. At 101, Khanna's paintbrush has a pulse that carries the memories of a life in Pakistan before he moved to Shimla after Partition, and eventually Bombay, where he found his footing as an artist with the Progressive Artists' Group. *Marching from the Margins* at Patna's Bihar Museum—in collaboration with the Institute of Contemporary Indian Art—therefore attempts the extraordinary feat of capturing Khanna's movement through time and space, observing those who have built empires, but have been relegated to the footnotes of history.







MOVING IMAGES
Clockwise from top, 'Untitled' (oil on canvas, 2014), 'Armoured Car on Patrol' (oil on canvas, 1947) and 'Untitled' (mixed media, 2005)

According to Siddharth Sivakumar, curator of the exhibition, the term "movement"—also the exhibition's theme—can connote many things in Khanna's seven-decade-long career. "It may be physical, involving migration, labour, displacement or travel. It can also describe the movement of ideas, motifs, memories and metaphors. The exhibition follows these different forms of movement rather than treating it as a single theme," he says.

THE EXHIBITION, A RECORD OF THE ZEITGEIST OF A CENTURY, CAPTURES KHANNA'S MOVEMENT THROUGH TIME, SPACE AND HISTORY

Works like 'View From My Room' (1949), paintings and bronze sculptures of the Bandwallas, sit alongside the artist's musings on Biblical themes and stories. "Movement can also be spiritual or metaphorical. Read together, 'Pietà' and 'Emmaus' trace a passage from death to renewal. In 'Pietà', movement reaches stillness as Christ's body is held within Mary's grief. In 'Emmaus', movement resumes as a journey towards recognition, suggesting the renewal of faith," the curator says.

In this context, the Bihar Museum attains a special significance, with the city's legacy of as a conduit for labour, migration, pilgrimage and learning. This backdrop allows Khanna's observations to take centrestage, "as his interest lies not simply in the grandeur of a subject, but in the human experience it makes visible," says Sivakumar. ■

—Arshia

The exhibition is on display at the Bihar Museum in Patna till Oct. 12